A PRIVATE JOURNAL OF JOHN GLENDY SPROSTON U.S.N.

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WITH A NEW FOREWORD BY

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Editor's Introductory Note

THOSE who were acquainted with the documentary sources of Commodore Perry's *Narrative of the Expedition of an American Squadron to the China Seas and Japan* were slightly puzzled when "an original manuscript by an officer of Perry squadron," which presumably was not known to the Commodore, appeared on the market in 1926. It will be recalled that at the beginning of the expedition, Commodore Perry gave strict orders to those under his command not to communicate with any one in regard to the movements of the Squadron or its discipline and regulations. These topics were to be avoided in private letters, and to make certain that the command was enforced, the letters were censored. Journals and notes kept by members of the expedition were to be looked upon as belonging to the government. Therefore, at the end of the expedition in August, 1854, in Hongkong, they were collected and sent to the Navy Department on the U.S.S. *Mississippi*. Mr. Francis L. Hawks, who edited the *Narrative*, makes acknowledgement to them in the 'Prefatory Note,' but adds that the Commodore's journals and correspondence form much the larger part. After the task was completed, all the private papers were returned to their respective owners.

A Private Journal of John Glendy Sproston, a manuscript folio of 105 pages in the original half calf, was noted for the first time in the *Catalogue* of the Anderson Galleries,[1] New York, in 1926, and was purchased by the Library of Congress. The consigner of the manuscript was not disclosed, and since then notwithstanding inquiries at the Galleries and elsewhere, it has not yet been possible to trace its history.

The U.S.S. *Macedonian* which had sailed from New York on April 11, 1853, joined the Squadron after much delay on February 14, 1854, at the American Anchorage in Edo Bay, and Sproston lost no time in recording the activities of the expedition. After a brief preliminary mention of the purpose of the present visit, he began his journal with

[1] See: Appendix, 7.

Captain Henry A. Adams' interview with the Japanese commissioners on the following morning in Kanagawa, and closed it eight months later in Hongkong only because he had an opportunity of forwarding it to his family in Baltimore through his friend, Kidder Randolph Breese. News from home took six to ten months to reach members of the expedition. Sproston wrote, 'Many changes of more or less importance have, no doubt, taken place, and the mind becomes anxious to know what they may be.' Fearing he might not have another chance of sending it in a near future, he entrusted the rough draft of his manuscript with a note: 'Sent in an unfinished state; will correct on reaching home, if I live.' Sproston lived through the strenuous duty of the East India Squadron, which lasted two more years after the conclusion of the Japan expedition, and returned home safely in 1856, but never had time to go back to his journal. Consequently, many foreign words and proper names, of which he was not certain, were left blank, except for one or two initial letters. Luckily, through existing sources in English and Japanese, it was possible to supply them.

It is difficult to believe that Sproston developed a sudden urge to keep such a detailed journal in Japan. He must have been in the habit of noting his impressions and experiences, and we regret that none of his letters and other journals have come down to us. That he had a taste for literature and, to some extent, literary talent, both he himself and his friend Breese, as well as the readers of the present journal, would grant. In this he hails the warmer weather when he can lounge on deck and indulge in reading. He would compose short epigramatic poems as he watched the rainbow; indulge in philosophical speculation as to the advantages of civilized or primitive life. He complains of the difficulty of writing on ship board, especially on the temperamental Japan Sea. Navigating unknown waters with the personnel cut to the minimum, calls of duty for the officers are frequent and strenuous. Yet he would not trade that life with anything else. 'Our long absence,' he writes, 'from fresh beef and civilization, though the cause of present discomfort, will ultimately prove a source of satisfaction to all concerned.'

Sproston's pen and pencil sketches excellently illustrate his text, and it is a matter for regret that there are only a few. He intended to draw many more and left space for them in the manuscript, but was not able to go back to them. In fact, several of his drawings are only in outline and half-finished.

Sproston is accurate in presenting facts which check well with those

mentioned in Perry's *Narrative,* but his journal is limited in scope and contains nothing which is not recorded in the latter. Its distinguishing quality, however, consists of his personal observations and comments, although naturally being under the restrictions imposed by the Commodore it had to be very discreet, and hence uninteresting. He characterizes the unpopular Commodore Perry with a sentence, 'No one appreciates a joke less than he does.' Samuel Wells Williams, interpreter, is dismissed as 'properly a missionary in China and a remarkably disagreeable man.' Sproston's description of the last episode in Edo Bay, when the Commodore Perry tried to force his way to Edo, is much more dramatic than that in the *Narrative.* A young Japanese interpreter on the U.S.S. *Mississippi* actually became ill when he saw the course of the Squadron and was ready to commit *harakiri.* Throwing his cloak and long sword to an American officer, he said, 'Take them, for I have no more need of them. My short sword will be all that I shall require.' Commenting on an apparent lack of reciprocal faith and understanding on the part of the Japanese, Sproston concludes: 'For the great misfortune attending the propagation of civilization and Christianity among heathens is that the class of foreigners with whom they first come in contact are actuated only by motives of gain, irrespective of the method by which it is obtained.' Yet Sproston is very hopeful, for he writes that, 'In all probability before many years, hundred of ships will pass through these island groups in the California and China trade.'

A short description of a visit to the coal field in the vicinity of Keelung, Formosa, is written by Kidder Randolph Breese and perhaps is the dullest part of the journal, since it is given up almost entirely to one small incident before he started on the excursion and to the expression of his personal feelings.

Edward M. Barrows, who quotes from the present journal, assumes that Sproston kept his diary concealed. I do not know on what authority he based his assumption. At the end of his writing, Breese jokingly adds the following: 'My observation will be noted down and, I hope, handed down to posterity as they certainly ought to, and when Commodore Perry sees this book which I shall certainly recommend him to do, he will acknowledge the truth of it.' The fact that the manuscript was sent on the *Mississippi,* the flag ship of the U.S. Expedition to Japan, leads one to believe that the journal was known at least to Captain Joel Abbot, and that Sproston was permitted to send it back to his family through his good friend, Kidder Randolph Breese.

SECTION FIVE

Breese's Description of the Formosa Coal Field

JULY 10TH

At last we have arrived off our port, this being the evening of the fifteenth day of our passage; and well satisfied are we all that it has come to a termination, for although two weeks is but a short time to be at sea, still circumstances alter cases, and in our case this is but a temporary stopping place. And glad am I that it is so, as we cannot expect to see anything of much interest, or at least not to compensate for a much longer delay in receiving news from home, our last dates being as far back as the first of December. Since then many changes of more or less importance have, no doubt, taken place, and the mind becomes anxious to know what they may be—good or evil. Hope delayed makes the heart sick.

Though the winds have not been propitious to us, still the weather has been generally very pleasant, and the warm day succeeded by a moonlight night, the tranquil sea, and soft south wind [which] have all combined to render the time agreeable. Now and then when in the neighbourhood of islands we have experienced a rain squall or sudden shift of wind to vary the monotony, but, once more on the open sea, the wind would return to the old quarter, and day and night be as before.

I remember on a particular mid-watch when the ship was heeling over to a freshening breeze and the whole heavens were resplendent with [the] clear light of the moon, the clouds began to gather along the horizon in dark, heavy masses, which, as they rose higher and higher until nearly overhead, became separated and detached, assuming the form of semi-circles. Each are extending over a wide space—some curves one way and some another—and the moon's rays shining in between them, made the whole have the appearance of an immense cage. Gradually, however, the lower clouds banked up in denser

masses in all directions, and vivid lightning commenced playing along the horizon, both to windward and down to leeward; and then followed the low, muttering sound of rolling thunder.

Faster and stronger came the wind squalls, accompanied by a few drops of rain. The moon had now disappeared from view, and all was darkness, except when the heavens were illuminated by the glare of the lightning, revealing for a brief instant the ponderous piles of clouds looming in all their majesty one above the other. Having handed all the light sails, the watch stood prepared for the coming change.

Suddenly the wind lulled, the heavy canvas flapped listlessly against the masts, but only for a moment. A bright flash, a heavy peal, and the squall was upon us! Down came the wind and rain, and over on her lee side careened the ship, until, gaining an impetus from the power of the wind, she rushed like an arrow through the water, whilst the low flapping of our mainsail, as its widespread folds were furled to the breeze, but added to the confusion of the scene.

Again the wind suddenly ceases, then shifts and comes out astern, and before the ship can be brought to her course it is ahead, and has taken us aback.

Hard up! And our swift progress through the water enables us to fill on the same tack. Once more the squall thickens round us, and the rain falls in slanting, blinding sheets.

See the halliards clear, for it blows a gale!

In the wind, let her go off, flatten in—all full again, meet her! Crash! goes the thunder overhead—that flash must have been very near.

Flap, sound the sails against the masts—what will come next?

And now the rain ceases; the heavy clouds pass to leeward; the moon shines brighly overhead; the old wind springs up, and the squall is past. Like so many sons of Neptune, just risen from their watery element, the sailors shake their dripping clothes, and in obedience to the word of command climb aloft and loose the lighter sails to the breeze—and again the ship is clothed in her white suit from deck to truck.

Strike the bell eight, call the watch, tumble up below these—the watch is over!

And when relieved, each one goes below, and, turning in, is soon oblivious of wind and rain, thunder and lightning, and all the other changes of the elements.

12 at night. I had just dropped off into a pleasant slumber, having enjoyed the evening breeze until a short time previous on deck, when I was awakened by a great noise on deck and nearly rolled out of my bunk, the ship heeling over very much. The word was passed fore and aft for all hands to tumble up and shorten sail. A few moments and I was on deck, just in time to see the topsails clewed down to a very heavy squall which, it appears, had come up very unexpectedly, and proved to be the first of a numerous series which followed each other in succession during the night. We were very fortunate in having just cleared the islands, which gave us thirty miles sea room to work ship in.

In the morning when I turned out we were under topsails and courses running free. Keelung Island was close aboard, a small conical island four miles from the port, and looming up through the mist right ahead rose the high land of Formosa. Several heavy squalls obliged us to lay to until they cleared off, when, taking advantage of a lull, we stood in, taking on board a Chinese pilot; and before meridian were at anchor in the harbour of Keelung.

Capt. [N. Guerin], R. N., in command of a merchantman,[121] the—, visited this port some time ago and made a rough chart of the harbour, which answers all practical purposes, although incorrect in some respects. We will, however, give it a thorough survey before leaving.

The entrance is narrow with considerable high land all round. Proceeding up about a mile, it becomes narrow and shoals. Beyond this is the junk anchorage, opposite one end of the town, which is built upon the left bank off the harbour and extends upwards of a mile or more, consisting in most places of one, and, at most, of three streets running in a parallel direction.

The above is a rough outline of Breese, Watters, and myself, cutting and eating pineapples under an old Chinaman's shed, after a long morning's walk through the town in the hot sun, which had somewhat fatigued us; and we proposed and put into exectuion this method of refreshing ourselves, much to the gratification of the old stall-keeper and amusement of a large crowd of men and boys who encircled us during the operation, examining our dress and arms as great curiosities (as they were, no doubt, to them); the only objection to their

[121] 'Before the visit of the United States squadron to these seas, a French chart, constructed by Monsieur N. Guerin; Captaine de vaisseau, and published in Paris in 1848, was the most approved guide.' THE EXPEDITION OF AN AMERICAN SQUADRON. v. 1, p. 489.

presence being the difficulty we found in keeping their not over-clean hands off our white clothes.

We called on the Chief Mandarin[122] at his residence and were politely received by his son, the old man not being in. Refreshments were served, consisting of pop-corn rolls, tea, and cakes. I sat next to the young mandarin, and his pipe-bearer, standing between us, passed the brass narghile alternately to each, and I found the flavor very agreeable. We sat in the paved court or reception room, with a large crowd at the entrance (and partly in the room) gazing on in clamorous admiration. In the afternoon the mandarin[s] visited the ship, with which they were very much [pleased] and presented us with a bullock.

This afternoon landed a little above the ship, and visited a Chinese fortification, consisting of a solid stone bastion some fifteen feet in height and the same in thickness, with a breastwork extending along the front, pierced for larger guns at intervals, with loopholes between for musketry. At the present time there are no guns mounted. Like forts are erected near various quarters of the town, which is circled by a stone wall on the shore sides, some six feet in height, with bastions and loopholes at regular distances. Just now they are in daily fear of an attack from the rebels on the China side, and have, in consequence, they say, several hundred troops under arms, although in corroboration of the statement I have only seen a small encampment at one end of the town, containing perhaps a hundred or two armed men, two thirty-two pounders, and several jingals.

Their camp consists of about a dozen or so small tents, which after rain, the camp-ground being low, are nearly all afloat. The dress of the soldiers differs but little from the ordinary garments of the inhabitants, and their appearance is anything but prepossessing. Each tent is occupied by some dozen soldiers, sitting on straw which covers the ground, and generally eating boiled rice as a means of passing the time when not sleeping.

Their cannon are mounted upon heavy thick planks, placed edgewise and bolted together (also scored in the middle to receive the trunnions). Here and in an open court opposite the tosh house are all the ordinance of the town. The largest piece is a 68 pounder. They are constructed by the Chinese themselves and cast with the base.

[122] 'We were taken afterward to the house of a mandarin whose name is *Le-chu-ou*, and title *Hip-top*, said to be the chief mandarin of the place.' THE EXPEDITION OF AN AMERICAN SQUADRON. v. 1, p. 157.

The streets of Keelung are a succession of arcades, with, for Chinese, very good ranges of shops on each side, and the pavements in front covered with a busy throng vending fruits and trinkets of every description and quality—except the best.

The whole presents a busy scene, which is the principal feature in all Chinese towns, caused in a great measure by the dense population inhabiting a small space; and when the streets are narrow, as in Canton, excepting [in] a few of the principal streets, the rush almost endangers personal safety.

The districts in which vegetables, fish, poultry, and fruit are sold present a very goodly array of the above-mentioned provisions. The pineapples are plentiful, also mangoes of a good quality; the sweet potatoes, especially the top ones, large; eggs, principally those of ducks. Bananas are scarce, the country being too hilly for them, [and] the same may be said of coconuts. The watermelons are excellent—not large, but with very thin rinds.

Continued our walk through the town, stopping now and then to examine the contents of the stores, or accepting the often-repeated invitation to walk in and take a pipe and cup of tea, on which occasions we would write in English for them, or draw a rough chart, showing the vessels' track and destination, with which they were very much pleased, many understanding the position of the countries, represented on the chart, very well.

Passing through and out by the opposite end of the town, followed a path leading by numerous paddy fields. Ascended the side of a hill by a stone-paved road, considerably out of repair, evidently from the effect of rains; and when on the summit enjoyed a fine view of the dark-green and hilly country, the town beneath and harbour beyond.

Here and there were immense mud-flats, marring the view with their moist dingy brown, and telling too truly by the miasmatic atmosphere which quivered above them, of disease and death to all foreign to the climate. Noticed several trees near-by whose [trunks] and twisted branches had grown together in a very singular manner.

Birds of a kind or kinds, that I had never seen before were singing and flitting about in every direction. Heavy clouds were gathering in the west, and the distant sound of thunder came muttering among the hills, and soon followed a refreshing shower of rain, which cleared off in a few minutes, giving the atmosphere a fresh elastic feeling, making the grass and herbage to glisten in their renewed vigor, and as the setting sun appeared from among the now scattered clouds, a

half-circle rainbow appeared in view, close to us, adding beauty to the scene.

'A rainbow at night
A sailor's delight.'

On our way back stopped at several farmhouses, where in every case our gallant bearing in encountering the dogs who invariably made hostile demonstrations towards us, caused the women, at least, to decamp, and left us masters of the household. But we generously forebore, and contented ourselves with an examination of the premises, and then left them to the rightful owners.

Retracing our steps through the town, were overtaken by the rain unexpectedly, and seated ourselves in consquence under a covered way, and whilst there a young Chinaman offered us in a pressing manner some rice cakes, which we as politely declined, having but little faith in their cul[inary] abilities. He then exchanged them for a handful of betelnut chews, but with no better success, as we preferred keeping our teeth white. But not to discourage him I presented him with a string of cash (Chinese money) for which he was very thankful, not having in all probability ever received a gift before in his life.

We did the same to an old man selling pineapples near-by, and they both followed us with pineapples in their hands for some distance, and were really very much disappointed because we would not accept them. We did not on this occasion, as before, endeavour to purchase chickens or ducks, feeling no desire to stand amidst an admiring crowd with sword on one side and pistol on the other and cheapen[123] fowls, so took a *sampan* (native boat) and returned to the ship.

Several of the officers, this day, visited a coal mine about a mile from the town. They found it of easy access and apparently good quality. The mandarins state that the junks load with this useful, and, in this part of the world, scarce article, at a port eighty miles to the southward of this place. We wanted to form a party, and, assisted by a Chinese guide, make a land excursion to the mines, but on inquiry we found that on account of the barbarous tribes—and, as they say here, also cannibals—which infest the country, none of the Chinese would show us the way; so here the expedition ends, no doubt.

We visited this port with two objects in view; namely, to obtain coal (which we have at least found) and to discover if there were any prisoners upon the islands—unfortunate seamen cast away on this

[123] Archaic, used in the sense 'to beat down the price of'.

inhospitable land and doomed either to death or slavery. But on this point we have been unable to gain any information, as the Chinese have but little intercourse with the savage tribes, that we can discover, holding but an insecure footing themselves and liable to attacks from their formidable enemies at any moment. This is in every sense an unknown island to civilized nations, and years will in all probability lapse before any determined steps will be taken to explore it to any great extent.

Since our arrival mandarins have visited the ship, but today the Governor or Chief Mandarin visited the ship, accompanied by two others of the same grade, but lower on the scale, and attended by an escort of ragged soldiers, bearing pipes and red umbrellas. There are seven grades of mandarins in China.[124]

The Governor of this place is of the third grade; those who accompanied him, of the fifth and sixth respectively. He was a tall, slim, dark-complexioned person, inferior in personal appearance to one of the others, who was very well formed, and also of a prepossessing bearing. Everything excited his curiosity that he saw, as a ship of this size has never visited this harbour before, and [he] showed great pleasure in being saluted with *three guns* (that being a Chinese salute). The Captain today presented him unofficially—that is, through the purser[125]—with a number of ship's knives, scissors, and other articles of interest, as curiosities to them. This treatment has placed fresh provisions and fruits at our command in much to be desired quantities, which we all willingly take advantage of, for I learn today that we have a hundred men on board more or less affected by scurvy, so that a change from salt to fresh diet has become an absolute necessity.

I have since learned that there are nine grades of mandarins, and that the Governor is of the 4th grade and the other two of the 6th and 7th, wearing blue, white, and yellow buttons, or top balls on their conical hats, which mark denotes the grade of the wearer.

JULY 16TH

This afternoon, the weather being pleasant, I went on shore more for exercise than observation, but who can visit a foreign people or a strange place without seeing something to attract his attention? And such was the case with myself on this occasion.

[124] Not seven, but nine, as later corrected, known as *Chiu-p'in*.

[125] Purser Richard T. Allison.

We landed at the lower end of the town, passed through the principal street, encountering the usual quantity of noise and confusion, much of which emanated from the numerous small gambling shops which are to be met with in every Chinese town. Passed the *hongs*, and then the graveyards, or continuous burying place, which reaches nearly down to the water's edge, and here we saw an exhumed coffin among a collection of graves, several of which were new. It consisted of the portion of a trunk of a tree hollowed out, cut off at one side, and boarded over. The excavation made for its reception in the ground is so shallow that I noticed in several instances the ends of the coffins protruding from out the raised mounds. We next came to the wooden bridge, supported on rough stone columns, which extends across a wide mud-bottomed stream, that is almost dry at low water, and again entered the town. One of the first persons I encountered was the Governor on his visit aboard. The fat old gentleman was fanning himself most energetically, and gave us a familiar nod, by way of recognition, making signs for us to enter at the same time, which we politely declined, and continued on.

Stopped at the tosh house and saw a number of women in white (their mourning dress) performing their devotions by prostrating themselves before the image, burning paper and waving it up and down, as they repeated their incantations. On each side of the altar there was a wooden figure of hideous aspect, one red and the other blue—gods of Peace and War.

As usual, an admiring crowd followed us wherever we went, much to our an[noyance], but we bore it as a necessary evil, and thought, in extenuation, how a Chinese would be treated similarly situated in our country.

Returning, we stepped into a house to observe the operation of one woman pulling out by means of a twisted cord the superfluous hair on the neck of another. It was very skillfully performed, although our presence evidently embarrassed them. We reach the landing by sunset and found officers and men bargaining for provisions of every kind, which are now much cheaper than when we first arrived.

JULY 17TH

ANOTHER day has passed and still no signs of the *Supply*. This is her 21st day out, and yet, though we made the passage in fifteen day[s], we expected to find the store ship in port on our arrival.

I[126] started this morning at half past four in the cutter for the famous mines of Formosa, from which so much benefit to the whole world (some few speculating Amer[ican] merchants) is to be derived, and for which I, poor fellow, was turned out of my ship to incommode some and benefit others. But, however, off we started: Mr. Jones,[127] the chaplain, under whose favored [tutelage] I am at present; the purser, an amateur; two Chinese guides, who to serve Mammon forgot their master; and a Chinese interpreter. Before going on, it would perhaps better to say that I was 'put out', to use a ladies' phrase, and this may, in fact, account for the gloomy narrative which follows. And perhaps still more better [sic] would it be should I tell my grievances, that my account might be looked over more leniently than it would otherwise have been.

To begin with, I was told that I need not make any preparations as regards chow-chow for the next day (today), as they—the purser and chaplain—had prepared all. And as everyone knows that travelling in an open boat on a hot day on an empty stomach is contrary to all the laws of nature, as soon as I was dressed, I looked around for my breakfast. Not having received any invitation to partake of one which was cooking in fine style, notwithstanding it was so early in the morning, I began to feel queer and thought of being slighted. Thinking that if I did not try for my *déjeuner* no one would for me, a lucky idea struck me as I thought. 'Perhaps Mr. Jones might have some things to be attended to (although the matter and arrangement had been thoroughly canvassed and arranged the previous day) and I ought to go in the cabin (where the breakfast was going) and find out,' which I did.

Oh, sorrowful moment! There were but two plates on the table and the purser, standing by, waiting for the chaplain to sit down and commence his attack upon the nice viands displayed before him.

I drew myself up to my full height, five feet ten without shoes—not 'in my stocking feet', as I once expressed it before some ladies who were dreadfully shocked at the expression—and modestly asked if the chaplain was dressed.

Receiving a polite negative in reply I withdrew, fully determined to sacrifice myself to the raw pork and moldy hardtack of the boat crew, and had hardly got more than a few paces on my way when—oh, luck! —a twang went through my bowels, which, followed by others in

[126] The handwriting changes here and is that of Kidder Randolph Breese, who was temporarily attached to the *Macedonian* during her cruise to Formosa.

[127] Reverend George Jones (1800–70), naval chaplain and author.

quick succession, soon reduced me to the idea of filling up that awful void and causing me to place, more than ever, my implicit reliance upon the old adage that Nature abhors a vacuum. I perfectly agreed with Nature. I called the steward, explained my situation, received his commiseration with a sigh as he told me that he was so sorry and why had I not told him before, etc. and asked him to get me a cup of tea while I took a stroll on deck and examined the fittings of my boat.

I could not have been on deck five minutes when up he came (the steward) and told me my tea was ready. I thought he might have brought it up, only a cup of tea, and I was going to be gone in the hot, broiling sun for the whole day. 'Well,' I thought, 'that, better than nothing,' and down I went to the pantry. Imagine my surprise, my delight, my ecstasy at the sight—and I really believe the good steward enjoyed my delight as much as I did the sight. There was a plate with a breast, a back, two legs, two wings, side bones, etc. of a chicken—in fact, I might say there was a whole chicken—and near it some fresh pork, devilled. When I left the pantry the teapot was nearly dry and nothing remained of the chicken but the bones.

How well I felt! No more rumblings, everything well stowed and in good trim. As old Dick Chapman would say, 'A child might play with me,' or, as the Emperor of China might remark, 'I have breakfast and now let all the world. . . .'

I was met on my ascent on deck by a cabin boy with, 'Mr. Jones wishes you to take breakfast with him.'

'Better late than [n]ever,' thought I. But, said I, with a perfect air of *bienséance*, I had breakfasted. Sproston's remark about pineapples—the difference existing between nowadays and formerly—has quite sobered me, and I will try now and proceed to the real object of the expedition.

The highest mandarin on shore, after having taken a second sober thought, declined to furnish guides to show the mines to the *Fanquis* [foreigner?] for fear the news of it might reach the ears of the authorities in China and he be deprived of his button for his civility. But he must have much mistaken the great American nation (which the ship here represents), did he think that we would give it up so, particularly with the *corps scientifique* on board, of which Mr. Jones is the head, and I having all under my protection (that is, I wear a sword and revolver constantly to prevent any unpleasant occurence taking place, such as being broiled and eaten or led away into captivity, perhaps to work some of the very mines about which so much interest is displayed).

However, through the aid of the Captain's steward, a Chinaman, guides were procured (I believe also at the connivance of the mandarin). They came on board at dusk last evening, talked mysteriously, and said that in two hours they would take us to the long-desired-to-be-seen mines so near the water. They insisted upon being disguised as sea men, which was soon done, and as they were clean, could not have been recognised by their best friend as natives of Keelung.

Equipped as I have described, we shoved off at half past four, early daylight. It was a delightful morning, cool and pleasant, just breeze enough ahead to ripple the water and not to stop the headway of the boat, and a fair tide, being everything to make one comfortable and happy. Being on this occasion a Cavalier and feeling myself as such and thinking that I had been treated as one (cavalierly), I lighted my cigar and wrapped myself in my own thought[s], they following the motions of my cigar smoke, [which], at first a confused mass and then breaking out and taking various forms, gradually disappeared (what shall I say to wind up this beautifully poetical idea? Shall it be the blue vault of heaven? No. I've hit it!) like snow before a March wind.

This must do now, as I've started at last in my story, until tomorrow, when probably my *observations* will be noted down and, I hope, handed down to posterity as they certainly ought to, and when Commodore Perry sees this book which I shall certainly recommend him to do, he will acknowledge the truth of it. Won't Johnny rave at my carelessness—Bloss !!!![128]

The foregoing is Breese's account of his expedition to the coal mine of Formosa, the successful issue of which is a great source of satisfaction to all, as it has placed beyond a doubt the fact of the existence of extensive veins of coal upon the Island, of easy access, and from all appearances of good quality. When we consider that not three hundred miles from this port (Shanghai) coal is selling for $60 a ton,[129] it is truly astonishing that more notice has not been taken of the existence of it here, and [a] depot for the useful article established.

It only shows clearly how much yet remains to be discovered and explored of the seaboard of China, a country inhabited by a people differing in every respect from other nations. Their manner of living in

[128] End of Breese's handwriting.

[129] From the report of Chaplain Jones to Commodore Perry: '. . . .by Captain Abbot's direction, to purchase all that was sufficiently large for our purposes, which I did at $16 for each hundred piculs. They demanded $20. The Hip-toy had said that we ought to give but $12, and $12 is probably the regular price; but we thought it cheap at $16, and were glad to get it at that. . . .' THE EXPEDITION OF AN AMERICAN SQUADRON. v. 2, p. 162.

particular, combined with the unhealthiness [sic] of the climate, will always be a great drawback to any but a slow and gradually increasing intercourse with them.

A few remarks might now be appropriately made concerning the history of the Island to the present day, which will solve the cause of many difficultes still existing to prevent for intercourse on their part with foreigners, and not the least will be found to have originated with Europeans themselves.

For the great misfortune attending the propagation of civilization and Christianity among heathens is that the class of foreigners with whom they first come in contact with [sic] are actuated only by motives of gain, irrespective of the method by which it is obtained, and which is generally, as proved by history, an unlawful one enforced by men who have been obliged to leave their own country from misconduct or from incompetency to restrict themselves within the bounds of propriety. In other words, they are but adventurers.

These are followed in time by a class of men of higher standing, at least in the commercial world, and who reflect all due credit upon the standing of enlightened nations as compared with semi-barbarians. But, fortunately, for the rapid advance of social intercourse, the pernicious effects of the first remain, a lasting evidence of the good faith on the part of those who, uninvited and undesired, have endeavoured to establish themselves in the homes of another people. When such is the state of affairs, what can be expected on the part of those thus maltreated but distrust [and] enmity?

Look at the behavior of the Spaniards and Portuguese in the Americas! Grasping avarice glossed over by a shadow of Christian chivalry governed their every act; the conduct of the Dutch, a selfish, sordid race, whose ruling motive is self-benefit and for self only. And yet these nations first visited and colonized China and Japan! What worse foundation for a future superstructure?

Formosa is a large island off the Province of Yokien [Fu-chien] China, from which it is separated by a channel from 90 to 120 miles in breadth. Its length is about 250 miles by 50 or so in width. It was the last conquest made [in] the present Tartar dynasty, and even now, it is only a conquest by name, as the Chinese are restricted to a very small part of the Island. Vessels have now and then been wrecked upon its inhospitable shores, [and] the fates of all have been death or captivity.

In the 17th century the Dutch had a colony here, but were in time

expelled by the pirate chief. Their desire for gain and method of obtaining it, at the same time neglecting to keep the colony in a proper state of defense, combined to produce their expulsion. It was here also that they met with retributive justice from the Japanese for some unauthorized act on their part towards the crews of several junks belonging to that nation. The Dutch had a factory and garrison at this very port. Coxinja[130] was the name of the pirate chief who drove them off the Island, not before, however, (and it may be said to their credit in this instance) they had propagated Christian principles extensively among the natives; but all signs of such a desirable reformation have disappeared long ere this present period.

[130] Dutch ruled over a large portion of Formosa from 1624–61, but they were ousted from the island by Kokusenya (Chinese Chêng Ch'êng-kung, 1624–62), the son of a Chinese pirate by a Japanese mother. But his rule was short-lived, and the island passed in 1683 under the control of the Chinese Government, which retained it until its cession to Japan in 1895.